COMPOSER OS V3.2

Musician’s Quick Start Guide

Worked examples for the finished V3.2 application. You will discover a scale, hear it, see it on the guitar, practise it, develop a short piece, and export MusicXML.

Go to Contents

How to use this book

This book follows one path: **Discover, hear, see, practise, develop, export.** Each worked example has a fast lane for players who already know the screen, then numbered steps that use the button names on the running app.

A blue **Verified** badge means the control was seen in the source or on the open application during this edition. An amber **Verify** badge means the route exists and the exact result still needs your ears on your machine. A purple **Manual** badge means you do the musical work outside Composer OS, usually in your notation program or a DAW.

Scale names such as Dorian come from the Tonal glossary (MIT). Numbers such as 1709 are the scale mask used by the Ian Ring link in **About this scale**. This book does not rename scales from that site.

BHL worlds A–F are not rewritten here. When a step is a BHL scenario, the text says **BHL s05** and points at **BHL Composer Quick Start** and **Creative Scenarios Handbook**, version 1.0.

EDITION

UI bundle seen while writing: v2.10.10, stamp 2026-10-16T14:07:23Z, git 862c142, on top of baseline commit 1072b365. Practice files in the working tree may be newer than that commit.

NOTATION

Sibelius was not launched. The quartet cell is a MuseScore Studio 4.7.5 plate in the handbook, scenario 14.4. This guide uses diagrams and screenshots.

Contents

How to use this book . . . 2
1 · Your first five minutes . . . 4
QS-01 First duo in two minutes . . . 5
QS-02 Open the MusicXML . . . 6
2 · Finding your way . . . 7
QS-03 Find the right page . . . 8
3 · Hear a scale, see it, play it . . . 9
QS-04 A Dorian . . . 10
QS-05 Minor pentatonic box and beyond . . . 11
QS-06 A named scale from the Tonal list . . . 12
QS-07 An unnamed scale by its formula . . . 13
QS-08 Export and save a practice session . . . 14
4 · Generate: one idea, many forms . . . 15
QS-09 Duo with your own chords . . . 16
QS-10 Single-line conversation . . . 17
QS-11 Song Mode hook . . . 18
QS-12 A four-bar riff . . . 19
QS-13 String quartet sketch . . . 20
5 · Colour with Pentatonic and Hexatonic . . . 21
QS-14 Kumoi colour . . . 22
QS-15 Triad-pair hexatonic . . . 23
QS-16 Augmented collection . . . 24
6 · Develop with BHL . . . 25
QS-17 BHL import and lock . . . 26
QS-18 World A against the bass . . . 27
QS-19 Three candidates, one pair . . . 28
7 · Arrange and finish . . . 29
QS-20 SQ to BB first chart . . . 30
QS-21 Engrave and print . . . 31
QS-22 Log a listening note in Evaluation . . . 32
Quick reference . . . 33
What Composer OS does not do . . . 34

1 · Your first five minutes

By the end of this chapter you will have a Guitar/Bass Duo file and you will know where to open it. You do not need a style theory yet.

QS-01 First duo in two minutes

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

Fast lane. Open Generate, choose the preset Guitar/Bass Duo, give the piece a title, and generate. Save the MusicXML.

1. Start Composer OS and stay on Generate. The top row of routes is the map for the whole app.

2. In the preset list, choose Guitar/Bass Duo. The registry describes it as clean electric guitar plus acoustic upright bass, with chord symbols.

3. Type a short title. Leave custom chords empty for this first pass so you can hear the preset's own harmony.

4. Generate. If the button is disabled, the page is still waiting for a required field. Read the status line before changing composers.

5. Save the MusicXML beside your other scores. Do not overwrite an older file.

LISTEN FOR

Two parts. The bass should have a line of its own, not only roots on beat one.

WHY IT WORKS

A duo is the smallest texture in which harmony, register, and silence are all audible.

✓ Verified ? Verify

Preset name is verified in the registry. A fresh generate was not clicked during this print run, so treat the first sounding result as something you confirm by ear.

QS-02 Open the MusicXML

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

Fast lane. Open the file you just saved in your notation program. Do not use a one-click host button as the only copy.

1. Keep the MusicXML. That file is the piece.

2. Open it in the notation program you already trust. Check the guitar staff and the bass staff, the bar count, and the chord symbols.

3. Press play there if you want sound. Composer OS can audition some pages, and that playback is a preview, not a finished recording.

4. If a part is missing, go back to Generate and read the status. Big Band and String Quartet can fall back to a planning file when export does not pass. A duo should be MusicXML.

LIMIT

This edition did not engrave the duo in Sibelius or MuseScore. Your notation program is the place to see the staves.

Manual

2 · Finding your way

The routes across the top are the job list. Pick the page for the job, then come back to Generate when you want a score.

QS-03 Find the right page

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

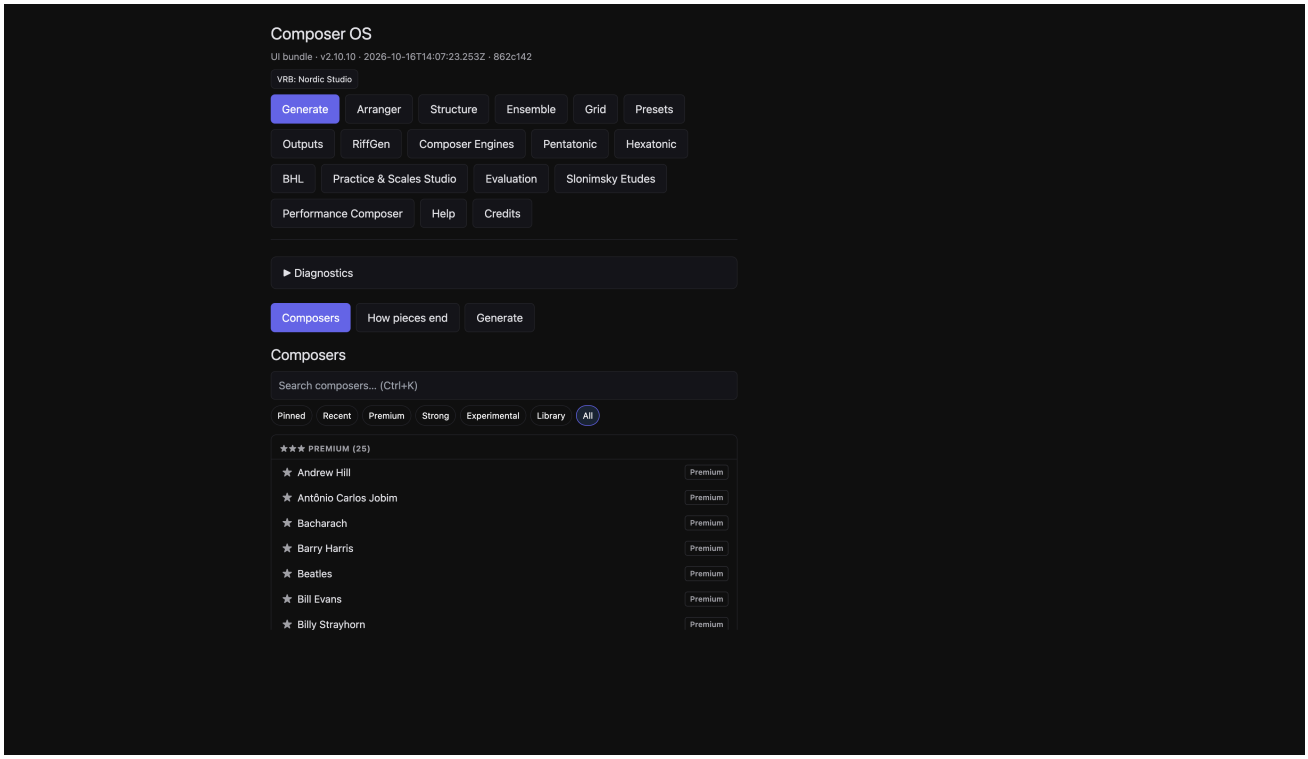


Figure 1: Screenshot. Generate route on the running app. The Composers tab is open. The inner Generate tab is a different control.

1. Practice & Scales Studio when you want to hear a scale, see the fretboard, and make an exercise.

2. Pentatonic for the twenty registered colours, a path, and a handoff into practice.

3. Hexatonic for six-note collections and whole-tone-pair triads. The phrase button reads Generate INSIDE / OUTSIDE / RETURN.

4. BHL when a locked bass and one harmonic world should rewrite the guitar. Read the V1.0 handbook before you invent a workflow.

5. Arranger, Structure, Ensemble, and Grid are real routes. Their exact musical effect is marked Verify until you try the control on your file.

WHICH PAGE

Scale: Studio. Colour path: Pentatonic. Six-note cell: Hexatonic. Locked-bass development: BHL. Full score: Generate.

✓ Verified ? Verify

3 · Hear a scale, see it, play it

The Studio opens on A Dorian. One root drives the fretboard, Play Scale, the exercise, and the export. There is no drone.

QS-04 A Dorian

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER · MASK 1709

Fast lane. Stay on A Dorian, press Play Scale, then play the fifth-position shape while you count intervals.

Dorian is a minor scale with a raised sixth. In A, that note is F-sharp. The same seven pitch classes as G major, with A as home.

1. Open Practice & Scales Studio. Root A, catalogue Essentials, row Dorian. Formula 1 2 b3 4 5 6 b7.

2. Press Play Scale. The player sends one octave up and back. The status line does not offer a drone.

3. On the fretboard, a filled circle is the root and a square is another scale tone. Switch dot labels to intervals if you want numbers on the app itself.

4. The diagram marks the sixth as a diamond so the bright note is obvious on paper. In the app that same F-sharp is a square labelled F# or 6.

LISTEN FOR

Sing A, C, E, then F-sharp. Minor triad, then the bright sixth.

TRY THIS

Press Generate with family Scale pathways and difficulty Beginner. Keep seed 1 if you want the same exercise again.

✓ Verified Next: QS-08

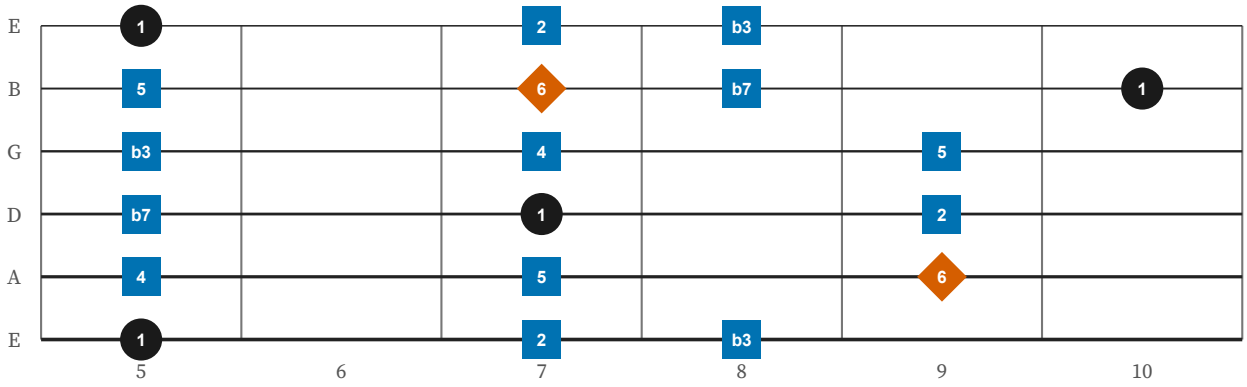


Figure 2: A Dorian, frets 5 to 10. Circle: root. Diamond: sixth, the note that makes Dorian bright. Square: other scale tones.

QS-05 Minor pentatonic box and beyond

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

Fast lane. In the Studio list, choose Minor Pentatonic, root A, press Play Scale, then generate a Pentatonic studies exercise.

1. Essentials includes Minor Pentatonic, formula 1 b3 4 5 b7. At A the notes are A, C, D, E, G.

2. Hear it once. Then set the position filter to lowest fret V and look only at that window. Dots are pitch locations, not a solved fingering.

3. Family Pentatonic studies, difficulty Beginner, then Generate.

4. The same colour also lives on Pentatonic as a registered collection. Practice this collection can send it back to the Studio.

WHY IT WORKS

The box is a map. The scale is a sound. Leave the box once the sound is familiar.

✓ Verified

QS-06 A named scale from the Tonal list

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

Fast lane. Set the catalogue to More Named Scales, search Hirajoshi, set the root, and press Play Scale.

1. More Named Scales holds glossary names beyond the Essentials row.

2. Search Hirajoshi. At root A the GUI check on 16 October 2026 showed notes A, B, C, E, F.

3. Open About this scale only when you want the mask, the Forte number, or the external number link. The panel starts closed on purpose.

4. Names are credited to Tonal. The link is a number, not a second name for the scale.

LISTEN FOR

A smaller set than Dorian. Fewer notes, more silence between them.

✓ Verified

QS-07 An unnamed scale by its formula

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE

Fast lane. Switch the catalogue to Advanced Set Theory, search a pitch-class list, and read the formula before you play.

1. All Scales and Advanced Set Theory list sets that may have no traditional name.

2. Search by pitch classes or by the mask. The heading still shows an interval formula when one can be spelled from the root.

3. Press Play Scale. If the row is only a mathematical set, treat it as a constraint, not as a style.

4. Generate a short pathway. If validation reports an error, do not export that exercise as a finished study.

MANUAL STEP

Naming the set for your own notebook is your job. The app will not invent a pretty title.

✓ Verified Manual

QS-08 Export and save a practice session

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

Fast lane. Generate, then Export MusicXML, then Save session.

1. Generate an exercise first. Export without a score asks you to generate or import one.

2. Export MusicXML downloads a file in the browser. On the desktop build it can write a path. This edition did not rebuild or install the desktop app.

3. Save session stores JSON with the scale, root, tempo, and the MusicXML inside it. Reopen session restores that file and does not regenerate the exercise.

4. Open File and Open in Finder run in the desktop app after a file has been written. In the browser they report that limit.

5. Loop, Repeat, and Metronome belong to the player. The metronome is not written into the score.

LIMIT

Develop in BHL Composer appears only when the sounding set matches a BHL colour. It is not on the default A Dorian screen.

✓ Verified ? Verify

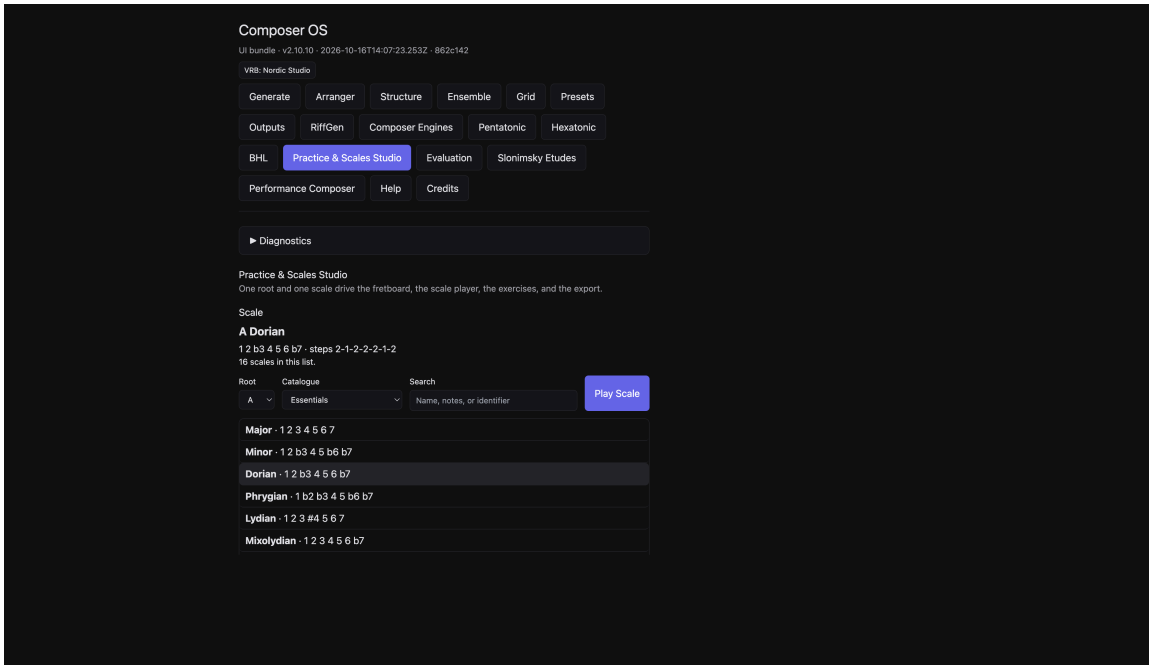


Figure 3: Practice and Scales Studio, Scale panel, on the running app. A Dorian is the default.

4 · Generate: one idea, many forms

The same harmonic thought can become a duo, a single-line conversation, a song plan, a riff, or a quartet sketch. The preset names below are the ones in the app registry.

QS-09 Duo with your own chords

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE

Fast lane. Preset Guitar/Bass Duo, type a short chord line into custom chords, generate, and read the symbols against the bass notes.

1. Use symbols you can already hear, for example Cmaj7, Am7, Dm7, G7, one bar each.

2. Generate and open the MusicXML.

3. Check that the printed symbol and the bass note can live in the same bar. If they fight, change the symbol or the bass, and keep a copy of the first file.

VERIFY

The exact custom-chord field label can read Custom chords. Confirm it on your Generate tab before you rely on a saved recipe.

✓ Verified ? Verify

QS-10 Single-line conversation

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE

Fast lane. Choose `Guitar–Bass Duo (Single-Line)` and generate a short chart.

The registry calls this the same duo harmony path with one note at a time in each hand of the conversation. Use it when block chords would hide the reply.

1. Generate 16 bars if the form control allows a length. If you cannot see a bar-count field, accept the preset length and note it.

2. In your notation program, look for bars where one part rests. Those rests are the breath.

3. If both parts speak on every beat, thin one line by hand.

> **LISTEN FOR**
>
> An answer that starts after the other part has finished a small shape.

✓ Verified Manual

QS-11 Song Mode hook

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE

Fast lane. Preset Song Mode. Write one hook sentence in pitches or in chord rhythm, then let the song plan place sections.

1. Song Mode plans hooks, sections, and rules, then realises a guitar and bass score.

2. Keep the hook to four bars. A long tune hides the section plan.

3. Per-section metre, pin, and avoid are documented in the Musician Guide. If you cannot find the control on the open form, mark that step Verify and do not invent a slider.

4. Export MusicXML and sing the hook before you add a bridge.

WHY IT WORKS

Form is easier to hear when the hook is already a sound, not a paragraph.

✓ Verified ? Verify

QS-12 A four-bar riff

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

Fast lane. Preset `Riff Generator`, or the `RiffGen` route, and keep the result inside four bars.

1. The registry describes loopable riffs of one to four bars on a strict grid.

2. Generate, then loop the MusicXML in your notation program. A riff that only works once is a phrase, not a riff.

3. Later, BHL scenario 33 can borrow the rhythm. Do not import the file into an engine the BHL limits forbid. BHL files do not go into the Riff Engine.

> **LIMIT**
>
> Riff Generator output is not a promise of a full song.

✓ Verified

QS-13 String quartet sketch

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE

Fast lane. Preset String Quartet. Generate. Open the MusicXML and count four string parts plus the harmony staff.

1. The registry says four strings plus a piano harmony staff when realisation and export pass. If they do not pass, you may receive planning JSON instead of a score. Read the status.

2. There is no orchestral page. A quartet sketch is not a film cue and not a symphony.

3. Harmonic voices such as Philip Glass or Nino Rota appear in the composer library. Confirm that the name is actually offered on the String Quartet form before you describe the result as that composer's quartet.

VERIFY

Which harmonic-voice rows are selectable on the quartet preset was not re-clicked for this print run.

✓ Verified ? Verify

5 · Colour with Pentatonic and Hexatonic

Pentatonic colour is a five-note field with a job: home, suspension, brightness, or strain. Hexatonic colour is a six-note field, often two triads.

QS-14 Kumoi colour

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE

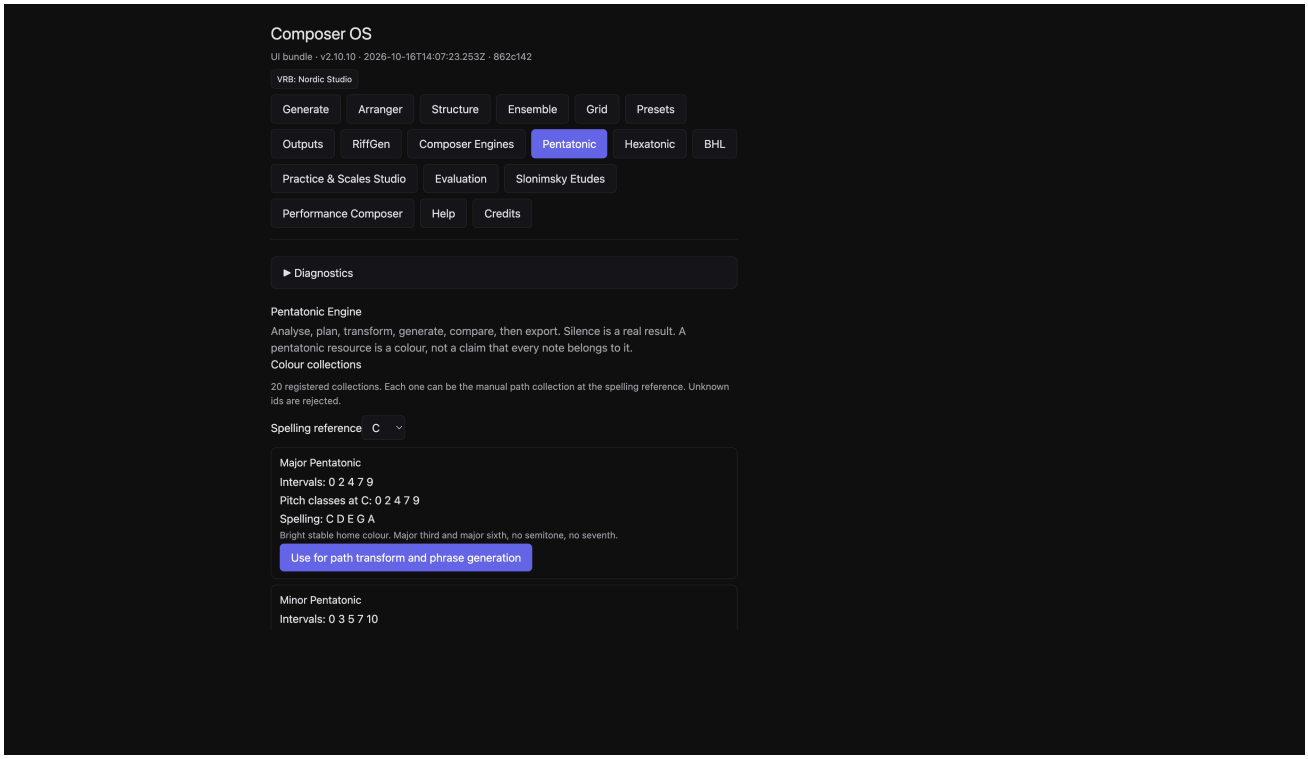


Figure 4: Pentatonic Engine on the running app. Twenty colour cards begin with Major Pentatonic.

Fast lane. On Pentatonic, press Use for path transform and phrase generation on Kumoi, then Generate path.

1. Kumoi at C is C, D, E-flat, G, A. Intervals 0, 2, 3, 7, 9. Soft dark colour, with a major sixth.

2. Spelling reference sets how the card is spelled. It is not a key signature by itself.

3. Generate a path with a required return home if you want the first collection back at the end. Open ending if you do not.

4. Practice this collection sends the set toward the Studio. Confirm the root when you arrive.

LISTEN FOR

E-flat beside D, then the bright A. The semitone is local.

✓ Verified

QS-15 Triad-pair hexatonic

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE

Fast lane. On Hexatonic, set Family to WPS triad pair, pick one pair, and press Generate INSIDE / OUTSIDE / RETURN.

1. A whole-tone-pair (WPS) is two triads whose notes add up to six. Read the Selection line: name, pitches, triads.

2. Generated notes are a phrase preview. The page says they are not an artistic approval.

3. Export MusicXML after a phrase exists. The button stays off until then.

4. The Core triad-pair laboratory can show common tones and voice-leading. Blind audition hides the name so you can listen first.

WHY IT WORKS

Two triads give the ear a door in and a door out without a scale run.

✓ Verified

QS-16 Augmented collection

WORKED EXAMPLE · ADVANCED

Fast lane. Family Scalar collection, choose Augmented t0, tonal centre C, then generate and export.

The spelling in the source is C, E-flat, E, G, A-flat, B. The mask is 2457. Transposing the whole set by a major third lands on the same notes.

1. Select Augmented t0. Read Pitches before you generate.

2. Press Generate INSIDE / OUTSIDE / RETURN. Export MusicXML.

3. The cell C, E-flat, E, G sits inside that set. A manual quartet built from it is Handbook scenario 14.4. The MusicXML is `assets/notation/hexatonic-cell-quartet.musicxml`.

4. Open in MuseScore 4 is a real Hexatonic button after export. This book still asks you to keep the MusicXML and open it yourself. The command-line engraving for this PDF did not succeed.

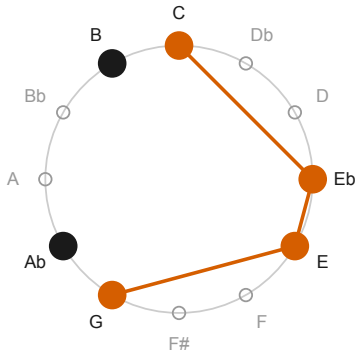


Figure 5: Augmented hexatonic on C, mask 2457. Joined dots: cell C, E-flat, E, G.

✓ Verified Manual

6 · Develop with BHL

BHL keeps a bass and repaints the guitar inside one world. The six worlds are fixed. Liquid harmony is world B. There is no BHL audio of its own, and no tablature. Full recipes are BHL scenarios 1–68.

QS-17 BHL import and lock

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE · BHL S05

Fast lane. Export a duo as MusicXML, open BHL, import, and lock the bass before you change the guitar.

1. Use a file you can stand to hear twice. BHL s05 is the import path in the V1.0 handbook.

2. Lock the bass. Later guitar edits should not move those bass pitches.

3. Do not send the BHL file back into the Riff Engine. That refusal is a published limit.

4. Performance Composer, if you use it later, receives MusicXML only.

LIMIT

No artist-named BHL approach. No automatic winner when you compare a pair.

✓ Verified

QS-18 World A against the bass

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE · BHL S52

Fast lane. With the bass locked, set Harmonic world to A, Triad pairs.

World A holds two major triads a major second apart. They share no pitch class. C major and D major together are C, D, E, F-sharp, G, A.

1. Choose world A before or at the lock, as the V1.0 handbook describes.

2. Let the bass keep the ground. The guitar changes triad.

3. BHL s52 and s53 cover the pair and the choice. Follow those pages rather than a second copy here.

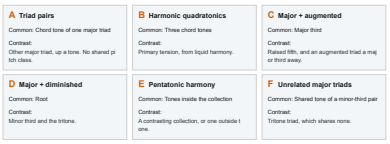


Figure 6: Worlds A–F, copied from the V1.0 handbook table. Not a new theory.

✓ Verified

QS-19 Three candidates, one pair

WORKED EXAMPLE · INTERMEDIATE · BHL S53

Fast lane. Make three candidates, compare them as a pair, keep one, and refine without losing the parent. BHL s54 is the refine rule.

1. Three candidates are for your ear. Comparison has no automatic winner.

2. Listen for the bass still matching the locked line.

3. Write one sentence about why you kept the pair. That sentence is the start of an Evaluation note, not a score.

LISTEN FOR

The candidate whose guitar changes the light without dragging the bass off the lock.

✓ Verified Manual

7 · Arrange and finish

A chart, a printed part, and a listening note. Orchestra and picture-sync stay manual.

QS-20 SQ to BB first chart

WORKED EXAMPLE · ADVANCED

Fast lane. Preset SQ → BB. Read the four-voice sketch, then the big-band section plan, and export only if the status says the score passed.

1. The registry describes a line-first SATB sketch, a review of four voices, then a translation into a big-band section plan.

2. This is not a full band arrangement with shout chorus, drum parts, and copyist cues unless those staves are actually in the file. Count the parts.

3. Big Band is the other preset: seven-part ensemble MusicXML when export passes.

4. Shaping a longer arc on Structure or Arranger is Verify until you have tried those pages on this file.

LIMIT

No orchestral rendering and no hit-point clock live in the app navigation.

✓ Verified ? Verify ✎ Manual

QS-21 Engrave and print

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

Manual

Fast lane. Open the MusicXML in your notation program, set A4, and export a PDF from there.

1. Guitar is treble clef, sounding an octave lower, labelled guitar. Double bass is bass clef, sounding an octave lower.

2. Put bar numbers at the start of each system. Keep chord symbols on one staff.

3. Dynamics and fermatas are manual if the exported file has none.

4. This Quick Start was not engraved in Sibelius. Do not treat a schematic in the Handbook as a plate from a publishing house.

QS-22 Log a listening note in Evaluation

WORKED EXAMPLE · BEGINNER

Fast lane. Open Evaluation after you have two files, and write what you heard in your own words.

1. The route exists. The exact form of a comparison was not re-run for this edition, so confirm the controls on the page.

2. Write three lines: what stayed, what changed, what you will play tomorrow.

3. A note is not an approval of the piece, and it is not a GCE release score.

WHY IT WORKS

A decision you can read next week is more useful than a second generate you cannot remember.

? Verify Manual

Quick reference

Studio. Play Scale, Generate, Generate another, Export MusicXML, Save session, Reopen session. Families: Scale pathways, Melodic cells, Pentatonic studies, Triad and dyad studies, BHL colour studies, Rhythmic studies. Levels: Beginner, Intermediate, Advanced. Bars: 4, 8, 16. Metres include 4/4, 3/4, 5/4, 6/8, 7/8.

Pentatonic. Use for path transform and phrase generation, Generate path, Practice this collection, Save project.

Hexatonic. Family Scalar collection or WPS triad pair. Generate INSIDE / OUTSIDE / RETURN. Export MusicXML.

Generate presets. Guitar/Bass Duo. Guitar–Bass Duo (Single-Line). Wyble Etude. Slonimsky Etude. Martino Linear. ECM Chamber. Song Mode. Big Band. String Quartet. Riff Generator. SQ → BB.

No keyboard shortcut list is printed here. The Pentatonic search on Generate shows Ctrl+K for composer search. Do not assume that chord works on every page.

What Composer OS does not do

These limits are quoted from the source and the BHL V1.0 manuals.

- BHL has no audio of its own and no tablature.
- BHL files are not imported into the Riff Engine. There is no artist-named BHL approach.
- Performance Composer receives MusicXML only.
- Comparison of a pair has no automatic winner.
- The six BHL worlds A–F are fixed. Liquid harmony is world B. There is no separate Liquid Harmony button inside BHL.
- Practice has no drone. `Develop in BHL Composer` is conditional. `Use in Generate` is not on the Studio page.
- `Open File` and `Open in Finder` are desktop actions. This edition did not install the desktop app.
- There is no orchestral score engine and no film-sync clock in the route list. Those jobs are manual after MusicXML export.
- Electronic sound design happens in your DAW after export.
- `Arranger`, `Structure`, `Ensemble`, and `Grid` are routes. This book does not invent their internals.
- A generate status that returns planning JSON is not a finished score.